

The Yellow Wallpaper

Charlotte Perkins Gilman · 1892

First published: The New England Magazine, Jan 1892

TEACHER EDITION · CURRICULUM UNIT

Common Core edition (standards shown for this framework only)

One 90-minute lesson (the whole story), with an optional take-home essay

Syllabus · 90-minute lesson plans · lecture scripts · vocabulary · quizzes with keys · writing prompts at eleven rigor levels · SAT-style items · whole-book test · essays

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Contents and unit overview

1. Unit overview and the 90-minute lesson
2. Syllabus (weekly pacing)
3. Lesson 1: introduction (author, context, reception, overview)
4. Lesson plans and lecture scripts (chapters 1–1), each with vocabulary, discussion questions, annotation focus, quiz and key, writing prompts and SAT-style items
5. Unit test (eleven rigor versions) with answer keys and scoring guides
6. Final paper
7. Essay assignments at eleven rigor levels

Edition: Reading text: https://en.wikisource.org/wiki/The_Yellow_Wall_Paper (revision 15679493), cleaned for Liber et Libri.

Grades: Grades 11–12 (scales to graduate via rigor levels). Short story: read whole in one 90-minute lesson (assign longer stories as pre-reading). The scaffolded-support track works from the full text with scaffolds. **Weeks:** 1. **Class days:** 2 × 90 minutes (1 chapter lessons plus seminar, test and essay days).

Essential questions

- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about women and medical authority?
- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about confinement and madness?
- What does The Yellow Wallpaper suggest about voice and silence?

Objectives

- Students will cite at least 2 quotations, with locations, to support each written claim about what the text says explicitly and implicitly (scored on the writing-prompt rubric).
- Students will trace one theme across at least 3 sections of the story in the final paper, earning at least 70 of 100 rubric points.
- Students will explain how characters, setting and point of view interact in at least 3 exit tickets, each meeting the claim-evidence-reasoning criteria.
- Students will determine the in-context meaning of taught vocabulary, scoring at least 80% on the vocabulary items of the story quizzes.
- Students will write an argument with a clear claim, reasons and relevant evidence, scoring at least 80% on the unit test's short-answer scoring guides.

Standards: Common Core

RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2, RL.9-10.3, RL.9-10.4, RL.9-10.5, RL.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2, RL.11-12.4, RL.11-12.5, W.9-10.1, W.11-12.1, L.9-10.4, L.11-12.4

Common Core State Standards (ELA-Literacy), thecorestandards.org

Assessments: Daily story quizzes (auto-graded); Weekly writing prompt (rubric); Socratic seminars (scheduled days); Whole-story test (scheduled day); Final essay (scheduled day); College Sophomore and above write one essay of the five
Differentiation: Every prompt and quiz has eleven rigor levels (Scaffolded support through Graduate / PhD); the app applies student override, then class standard, then the automatic level. Each prompt is tagged for Common Core, Indiana 2023, Dual Credit (Indiana College Core), AP and Cambridge where they apply.
Materials: Liber et Libri reader; Annotation journal; Story lecture slides or script

The 90-minute lesson

#	Segment	Mode	Minutes	Clock
1	Bell-ringer	You do	8	0–8
2	Vocabulary with etymology notes	I do	10	8–18
3	Background and context	I do	10	18–28
4	I do: modeled close reading	I do	12	28–40
5	We do: guided annotation	We do	15	40–55
6	You do: independent annotation	You do	15	55–70
7	Discussion	We do	10	70–80
8	Exit ticket / chapter quiz	You do	7	80–87
9	Closure	I do	3	87–90
	Total		**90**	

Syllabus

Week	Chapters	Lessons	Focus and activities	Assessment
1	*Introduction: author, context and reception* The Yellow Wallpaper	2 × 90 min (180 min)	*women and medical authority* • Daily 90-minute lesson: bell-ringer, vocabulary and word histories, background, I do / We do / You do, discussion, exit ticket, closure • Story quizzes in the app • Introduction: author, context and reception • Writing prompt at assigned rigor (one graded per week)	Quiz average plus one graded writing prompt

Lesson plans and lecture scripts

Each chapter is one 90-minute class. Scripts are a starting point; adapt them to your students. Teacher summaries contain spoilers.

Lesson 1: Introduction to The Yellow Wallpaper

Objective: Students will explain, in a 3-sentence exit ticket, how one fact about Charlotte Perkins Gilman's life or times connects to women and medical authority in “The Yellow Wallpaper”, and will set up a reading journal with a prediction and a question for each of 3 themes (women and medical authority, confinement and madness, voice and silence).

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2

Author biography

Charlotte Perkins Gilman was born in Hartford, Connecticut, on 3 July 1860, a relative of the Beecher family (Harriet Beecher Stowe was her great-aunt). After the birth of her daughter in 1885 she suffered severe depression and in 1887 was treated by the neurologist S. Weir Mitchell with his "rest cure," which forbade intellectual work; she later said it brought her near breakdown. She separated from her husband, moved to California and became a lecturer and writer on women's economic independence (Women and Economics, 1898) and author of the utopian story Herland (1915). Facing incurable cancer, she ended her life on 17 August 1935.

Historical and cultural context

In the nineteenth century, women with depression or "nervous" illness were often prescribed the "rest cure" of the neurologist S. Weir Mitchell: isolation, bed rest, overfeeding and a ban on intellectual work. Gilman underwent a version of it after the birth of her daughter in 1885. Married women had few legal rights, and doctors (usually men) had great authority over their patients.

Publication and reception, then and now

First published in The New England Magazine in January 1892. Gilman later said the editor of The Atlantic, Horace Scudder, rejected it, writing that he could not forgive himself if he made others as miserable as he had made himself.

Then: Many readers read it as a horror story about madness; a Boston doctor protested that it could drive readers insane.

Now: A foundational feminist text, rediscovered in the 1970s (the Feminist Press reissued it in 1973), and a classic of psychological horror and the unreliable narrator.

Overview (spoiler-free)

A young mother, taken by her physician husband John to a rented country house for a "rest cure," keeps a secret journal. She is forbidden to write and confined to a former nursery with hideous yellow wallpaper.

Main themes

- oppression of women.

- mental illness and medical authority.
- imprisonment and freedom.

Why it matters

The story helped change how people thought about depression and women's autonomy, and it remains a powerful study of how silencing someone harms them.

Spoilers · teacher only

She becomes convinced a woman is trapped behind the wallpaper's pattern, and in the end she tears it off, identifies with the trapped woman, and creeps around the room as her husband faints.

Lesson plan (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
Before we open The Yellow Wallpaper: What happens when someone isn't allowed to express how they really feel?
Prompt: Before we open The Yellow Wallpaper: What happens when someone isn't allowed to express how they really feel?

8–18 min · Key terms · I do (10 min)
Key literary terms for the unit.
unreliable narrator; journal/epistolary form; symbol; rest cure; feminism.

18–28 min · Mini-lecture: author, context, reception · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture on the author, the historical context and the reception (read or adapt the script).
About the author. Charlotte Perkins Gilman was born in Hartford, Connecticut, on 3 July 1860, a relative of the Beecher family (Harriet Beecher Stowe was her great-aunt). After the birth of her daughter in 1885 she suffered severe depression and in 1887 was treated by the neurologist S. Weir Mitchell with his "rest cure," which forbade intellectual work; she later said it brought her near breakdown. She separated from her husband, moved to California and became a lecturer and writer on women's economic independence (Women and Economics, 1898) and author of the utopian story Herland (1915). Facing incurable cancer, she ended her life on 17 August 1935. The world of the book. In the nineteenth century, women with depression or "nervous" illness were often prescribed the "rest cure" of the neurologist S. Weir Mitchell: isolation, bed rest, overfeeding and a ban on intellectual work. Gilman underwent a version of it after the birth of her daughter in 1885. Married women had few legal rights, and doctors (usually men) had great authority over their patients. Publication and reception. First published in The New England Magazine in January 1892. Gilman later said the editor of The Atlantic, Horace Scudder, rejected it, writing that he could not forgive himself if he made others as miserable as he had made himself. Then: Many readers read it as a horror story about madness; a Boston doctor protested that it could drive readers insane. Now: A foundational feminist text, rediscovered in the 1970s (the Feminist Press reissued it in 1973), and a classic of psychological horror and the unreliable narrator.

28–40 min · I do: the book in one passage · I do (12 min)
Model a close reading of one passage using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says her husband laughs at her, and adds that one expects that in marriage. Next, craft. I notice the tone is light, but "of course" and "one expects" show she has accepted being dismissed as normal. The strongest word is "laughs": laughing is not cruelty exactly, but it refuses to take her seriously, which is the core problem in the story. Then, effect. What does this line show about the narrator's marriage? My answer: Gilman shows how a husband who controls his wife "for her own good" makes her fears seem silly; the casual tone hides a real lack of power.

> *John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage" slowly and put it in my own words: The narrator says her husband laughs at her, and adds that one expects that in marriage. Next, craft. I notice the tone is light, but "of course" and "one expects" show she has accepted being dismissed as normal. The strongest word is "laughs": laughing is not cruelty exactly, but it refuses to take her seriously, which is the core problem in the story. Then, effect. What does this line show about the narrator's marriage? My answer: Gilman shows how a husband who controls his wife "for her own good" makes her fears seem silly; the casual tone hides a real lack of power.

40–55 min · We do: overview and themes · We do (15 min)
Read the spoiler-free overview together and name the themes to track.
What the book is about (no spoilers): A young mother, taken by her physician husband John to a rented country house for a "rest cure," keeps a secret journal. She is forbidden to write and confined to a former nursery with hideous yellow wallpaper. Themes to track: oppression of women.: mental illness and medical authority.: imprisonment and freedom.:

55–70 min · You do: reading journal · You do (15 min)
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme, with a prediction and a question (example given).
Set up a reading journal: one page per theme with a prediction and a question. Page: women and medical authority. Prediction: the narrator's husband, a physician, will decide what she may do, and the journal will show what that costs her. Question: whose account of her illness should I believe, John's or hers?
Task: Set up a reading journal for The Yellow Wallpaper: one page per theme, each with a prediction and a question.
Exemplar: Page: women and medical authority. Prediction: the narrator's husband, a physician, will decide what she may do, and the journal will show what that costs her. Question: whose account of her illness should I believe, John's or hers?

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)
Whole-class discussion: why the book is still taught.
Why does The Yellow Wallpaper still matter? The story helped change how people thought about depression and women's autonomy, and it remains a powerful study of how silencing someone harms them.
Anchor question: Why might The Yellow Wallpaper still be taught today?
Facilitation: The story helped change how people thought about depression and women's autonomy, and it remains a powerful study of how silencing someone harms them.

80–87 min · Exit ticket · You do (7 min)
Exit ticket on the author and context (answer given).
Gilman was herself given the "rest cure" for depression in the 1880s. Why did she say she wrote this story? Answer: She wrote it to show the harm of the rest cure and to persuade doctors (including Dr. S. Weir Mitchell) to stop forbidding women all work and thought; accept answers that connect her own treatment to the story's purpose.
Exit ticket: Gilman was herself given the "rest cure" for depression in the 1880s. Why did she say she wrote this story?
Answer: She wrote it to show the harm of the rest cure and to persuade doctors (including Dr. S. Weir Mitchell) to stop forbidding women all work and thought; accept answers that connect her own treatment to the story's purpose.

87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)
Preview the first reading.
Tomorrow we begin reading: The Yellow Wallpaper.

Teacher notes · sources: Britannica, "Charlotte Perkins Gilman" (https://www.britannica.com/biography/Charlotte-Perkins-Gilman); Gilman, "Why I Wrote 'The Yellow Wallpaper'" (The Forerunner, October 1913) (https://www.gutenberg.org/); Charlotte Perkins Gilman, "Why I Wrote The Yellow Wallpaper" (The Forerunner, October 1913) (https://www.nlm.nih.gov/exhibition/theliteratureofprescription/); U.S. National Library of Medicine, "The Literature of Prescription" exhibition (https://www.nlm.nih.gov/exhibition/theliteratureofprescription/)

Flags (verify before teaching):

- Gilman's account of Scudder's rejection is her own recollection; quote it as such. Content note: mental illness and postpartum depression; Gilman later died by suicide (1935), which may come up in biography.

Lesson 2: The Yellow Wallpaper

Focus: confinement driving a woman into madness

Objective: Students will analyze how point of view develops in “The Yellow Wallpaper” by writing a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph that cites at least 2 quotations from the section, and will score at least 80% on the section quiz.

Standards: Common Core RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1, L.9-10.4

Content note (postpartum depression and psychosis, controlling marriage, suicidal thoughts, suicide, alcohol or drugs (mentioned)): Sensitive content: Postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage; suicidal thoughts. Preview the story, tell students in advance, and allow a pass on reading aloud. Keep discussion on how the writer uses these elements, not on graphic detail. This section mentions drinking or a drug (“…and lots of tonics and things, to say nothing of ale and wine and rare meat. Dear John! He l…”). Treat it as period custom or plot detail; name it plainly and don't glamorize it.
Student preview: Heads-up: this story includes postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage; suicidal thoughts. Support is available if this is hard to read.
Suggested language: “Why does the writer include this, and what does it make us notice?”
Safe messaging: Discuss the character's despair and what the text does with it; do not dwell on methods. Before the lesson, remind students that support is available and how to reach the counselor. Check in privately with any student who seems affected and follow your school's referral protocol. **Share with students:** If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today. Let a counselor know in advance that this story is being taught.

Teacher only · spoilers

A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes to see a woman trapped behind its pattern. On the last night she tears the paper off to free her, identifies with her, and creeps around the room; John faints at the sight.

Background: Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy.

Significance: A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection.

Lesson plan and lecture script (90 minutes)

0–8 min · Bell-ringer · You do (8 min)
Students write to the bell-ringer, then pair-share.
How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself? Write for five minutes. Starters: I think... because... / This connects to oppression of women because.... Content note before we start: Heads-up: this story includes postpartum depression and psychosis; controlling marriage; suicidal thoughts. Support is available if this is hard to read. If you or someone you know is struggling or thinking about suicide, call or text 988 (Suicide & Crisis Lifeline, U.S.) or talk with a school counselor today.
Prompt: How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?
Sentence starters: I think… because… · This connects to oppression of women because…
Strong response: A strong response takes a position and anticipates this: she is infantilized in a nursery.

8–18 min · Vocabulary with etymology notes · I do (10 min)
Five key words in context, with verified word histories.
Today's words: splintered — broken into sharp pieces; congenial — pleasant and well suited; provoking — annoying, irritating; humiliating — making one feel ashamed and foolish; tiresome — so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness. "splintered": Origin of "splinter": Middle Dutch splinter. "humiliating": Origin of "humiliate": Late Latin humiliātus; earlier Latin humilis ("lowly"). "tiresome": Origin: an English formation from tire + -some.
Words: splintered: broken into sharp pieces · congenial: pleasant and well suited · provoking: annoying, irritating · humiliating: making one feel ashamed and foolish · tiresome: so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness

18–28 min · Background and context · I do (10 min)
Mini-lecture (read or adapt the script).
Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy. A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection. Point of view: Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time. Symbolism: The wallpaper's pattern becomes bars; the woman behind it is the narrator herself and all women confined. Irony: John's loving care ("blessed little goose") is what harms her. Watch for the wallpaper: the domestic prison.

28–40 min · I do: modeled close reading · I do (12 min)
Model the close reading of the anchor quotation using the written think-aloud below.
First, meaning. I read "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" slowly and put it in my own words: She insists that the wallpaper holds secrets and that she alone can see them. Next, craft. I notice the claim is private and proud, using "nobody... but me," which cuts her off from everyone else. The strongest word is "nobody": it makes her knowledge feel special but also lonely, the sign of a mind being shut in. Then, effect. What does the narrator mean when she says only she knows the things in the paper? My answer: When she says only she knows the things in the paper, the narrator means her isolation has turned the wallpaper into her private world; what she sees there is really her own trapped situation, which no one around her will acknowledge.

> *There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120)*

Think-aloud: First, meaning. I read "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" slowly and put it in my own words: She insists that the wallpaper holds secrets and that she alone can see them. Next, craft. I notice the claim is private and proud, using "nobody... but me," which cuts her off from everyone else. The strongest word is "nobody": it makes her knowledge feel special but also lonely, the sign of a mind being shut in. Then, effect. What does the narrator mean when she says only she knows the things in the paper? My answer: When she says only she knows the things in the paper, the narrator means her isolation has turned the wallpaper into her private world; what she sees there is really her own trapped situation, which no one around her will acknowledge.

40–55 min · We do: guided annotation · We do (15 min)
Guided analysis of a second quotation; expected answers given.
Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest? Expected: "Of course" and "one expects" show she accepts being dismissed, which hints at her powerlessness. Ask: How does this line connect to oppression of women? Expected: She is infantilized in a nursery. (Irony.)

> *John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5)*

Ask: What words in this line stand out, and what do they suggest?
Expected answer: "Of course" and "one expects" show she accepts being dismissed, which hints at her powerlessness.
Ask: How does this line connect to oppression of women?
Expected answer: She is infantilized in a nursery. (Irony.)

55–70 min · You do: independent annotation · You do (15 min)

Independent annotation and a claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph (exemplar given).

Annotate the story for point of view, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Yellow Wallpaper develops the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.) Exemplar: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. When the text says "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120), it shows this directly. Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

Task: Annotate the story for point of view, symbolism (three marks with a margin note each), then write one claim-evidence-reasoning paragraph: what does this story suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? Then start your writing prompt at your assigned level (HS Sophomore: Analyze how The Yellow Wallpaper develops the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.)

Exemplar: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. When the text says "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120), it shows this directly. Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

70–80 min · Discussion · We do (10 min)

Structured discussion from the 30 tiered questions, with facilitation notes.

Anchor question: How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself? Ask: is the ending a defeat or a victory?

Anchor question: How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?

Facilitation: Ask: is the ending a defeat or a victory?

80–87 min · Exit ticket / chapter quiz · You do (7 min)

Story quiz in the app and an exit ticket (answer given).

Story quiz in the app, then: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? Support it with one short quotation. Model answer: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me", The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

Exit ticket: In one sentence, what does this story suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? Support it with one short quotation.

Answer: Model answer: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me", The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120). Accept any defensible claim backed by a quotation from the story; the answer key for the quiz is in the Quiz section.

> **87–90 min · Closure · I do (3 min)**
> Summarize the lesson and preview the next reading.
> *Today we saw how point of view shapes confinement driving a woman into madness. Key takeaway: she is infantilized in a nursery.*

Total: 90 minutes.

Teacher analysis (spoilers)

Literary elements

- **Point of view:** Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time.
- **Symbolism:** The wallpaper's pattern becomes bars; the woman behind it is the narrator herself and all women confined.
- **Irony:** John's loving care ("blessed little goose") is what harms her.

Themes and how they develop

- **oppression of women:** she is infantilized in a nursery.

Symbols and motifs

- **the wallpaper:** the domestic prison.

Key quotations (checked against the reading text)

- "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5) Irony.
- "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120) Obsession begins.
- "I've got out at last" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257) Her "freedom."

Model claim-evidence-reasoning

Claim: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement.
Evidence: "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120)
Reasoning: Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

Vocabulary with etymology notes

Word	Definition (in this sentence)	In context	Word history
splintered (verb)	broken into sharp pieces	*Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in*	"splintered": Origin of "splinter": Middle Dutch splinter. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/splinter#Etymology)

		the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.	
congenial (adjective)	pleasant and well suited	*Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.*	
provoking (adjective)	annoying, irritating	*But in the places where it isn't faded, and where the sun is just so, I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure, that seems to sulk about behind that silly and conspicuous front design.*	
humiliating (adjective)	making one feel ashamed and foolish	*It must be very humiliating to be caught creeping by daylight!*	"humiliating": Origin of "humiliate": Late Latin humiliātus; earlier Latin humilis ("lowly"). (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/humiliate#Etymology)
tiresome (adjective)	so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness	*In the daytime it is tiresome and perplexing.*	"tiresome": Origin: an English formation from tire + -some. (Liber et Libri origin note, https://en.wiktionary.org/wiki/tiresome#Etymology)

Discussion questions

1. How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?
2. Where does point of view appear in this story, and what effect does it have? Point to one passage.
3. How does this story connect to the book's larger concern with women and medical authority?

Classroom discussion questions (30, tiered)

Wait time after every question (3 s for DOK 1, 5 s for DOK 2, 8 to 10 s for DOK 3 and 4); think-pair-share on DOK 3 and 4; answer each response with a follow-up probe; close with student-generated questions. Focus sets by rigor level: Scaffolded support: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 11, 12, 13, 14, 21, 22; HS Freshman: 1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 12, 13, 14, 15, 22, 23, 24; HS Sophomore: 1, 2, 3, 4, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 23, 24, 25; HS Junior: 1, 2, 3, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18, 24, 25, 26, 27; HS Senior: 1, 2, 3, 15, 16, 17, 18, 25, 26, 27, 28, 29; AP: 1, 2, 16, 17, 18, 19, 20, 26, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Freshman: 1, 2, 17, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 27, 28, 29, 30; College Sophomore: 1, 2, 11, 18, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 28, 29, 30; College Junior: 1, 11, 12, 19, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 29, 30; College Senior: 1, 11, 12, 13, 20, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 30; Graduate / PhD: 1, 11, 12, 13, 21, 22, 23, 24, 25, 26, 27, 28

Literal / recall

1. What is the narrator's husband's job? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Physician
2. What is the narrator forbidden to do? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Work and write
3. In which room is the narrator kept? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: An upstairs nursery with barred windows
4. What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A woman creeping and trapped

5. How does the story end? [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: John faints and she creeps over him
6. Retell the three most important events of "The Yellow Wallpaper" in order, in one sentence each. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes to see a woman trapped behind its pattern. On the last night she tears the paper off to free her,…
7. Which characters appear or are mentioned in "The Yellow Wallpaper"? Name two and one thing each says or does. [DOK 1 · coldCallWithSupport · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: Names and actions taken from the story; check against the teacher summary.
8. Where and when does "The Yellow Wallpaper" take place? Point to the line that tells you. [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: A place/time detail quoted from the story.
9. Reread: "Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars." What does "splintered" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: splintered: broken into sharp pieces.
10. Reread: "Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good." What does "congenial" mean here, and what is literally happening in this line? [DOK 1 · turnAndTalk · wait 3 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.1] Look for: congenial: pleasant and well suited.

Inferential / analytical

1. What does "The Yellow Wallpaper" suggest about confinement driving a woman into madness? State the inference and the line that supports it. [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection.
2. Find one example of point of view in this story. What does it reveal that a plain statement would not? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: Look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know.
3. How does the symbolism in this story shape what we understand about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5): Irony. On symbolism: The wallpaper's pattern becomes bars; the woman behind it is the narrator herself and all women confined. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
4. In the passage that begins "Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it…", why might Gilman have chosen these particular words? Pick two and explain their connotations. [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Diction analysis of two words in the anchor passage.
5. What causes the main turn in "The Yellow Wallpaper", and what effect is it likely to have on what follows? [DOK 2 · followUp · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A woman recovering from what her physician husband John calls a 'temporary nervous depression' after childbirth keeps a secret journal during a summer 'rest cure' in an

old mansion. Forbidden to write or work, she is confined to a nursery with barred windows and hideous yellow wallpaper. She comes…

6. As the opening story, what does “The Yellow Wallpaper” set up that the rest of The Yellow Wallpaper will need? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A causal or structural link between this and the previous story.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120): Obsession begins. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
7. What can we infer about a character's motives from what they say and do here, as opposed to what they claim? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An inference about motive supported by a quoted line.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257): Her "freedom." Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
8. The bell-ringer asked: “How would you feel if you were not allowed to do the things that keep you yourself?” Now that we have read closely, how would you revise your first answer, and which line changed your mind? [DOK 2 · thinkPairShare · wait 5 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A revised answer anchored in the text.
9. Where does imagery appear, and how does it connect this story to the larger concern with women and medical authority? [DOK 3 · followUp · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.4, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.4] Look for: Look for sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5): Irony. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.
10. Background: Gilman (1892) based it on her own treatment by S. Weir Mitchell, whose 'rest cure' forbade intellectual work. She said she wrote it to save people from being driven crazy. How does knowing this change the way you read one moment in the story? [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: A specific moment reread in light of the context.
    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120): Obsession begins. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Evaluative / synthesis / creative

1. A critic might argue: “A foundational feminist text and a Gale Short Stories for Students (vol. 1) selection.” How far do you agree? Take a stand and defend it with two lines from the story. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A defended position with evidence and one counterpoint.
   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her

confinement. Useful evidence: “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257): Her "freedom." Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

2. Which character in this story acts most wisely, and which least? Judge them by a standard you name. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.3, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.3] Look for: An evaluation using an explicit criterion and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5): Irony. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

3. Rewrite one moment of “The Yellow Wallpaper” from the point of view of a different character. What does the new angle reveal or hide about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: A creative product with a rationale tied to the text.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120): Obsession begins. On point of view: Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

4. Write three questions of your own about “The Yellow Wallpaper”: one recall, one “why/how”, and one “should/what if”. Trade with a partner and answer theirs. [DOK 3 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: Student-generated questions at three levels.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257): Her "freedom." Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

5. Connect this story to confinement and madness: is the link strong or weak so far? What would Gilman need to show next to strengthen it? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A judgment of thematic development across the work.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5): Irony. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

6. Is the point of view in this story effective, or does it feel heavy-handed? Evaluate it as a reader would in a review. [DOK 3 · fourCorners · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.1, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.6] Look for: An evaluative judgment with criteria and evidence.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120): Obsession begins. On point of view: Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

7. Compare how “The Yellow Wallpaper” treats confinement driving a woman into madness with how another text, film or event you know treats a similar idea. What does The Yellow Wallpaper see that the other misses? [DOK 4 · socraticCircle · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A cross-text synthesis.

Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257): Her "freedom." Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

8. As the final story, does this ending resolve women and medical authority? Argue whether the ending is earned. [DOK 3 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.5, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.5] Look for: A prediction or judgment justified with textual clues.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5): Irony. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

9. Design a one-paragraph modern adaptation of this story (setting, characters, conflict). What must stay the same for it to still be about confinement driving a woman into madness? [DOK 4 · thinkPairShare · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A creative transfer that keeps the core idea.

   Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120): Obsession begins. Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

10. What question would you most like to ask Charlotte Perkins Gilman about this story, and what answer do you think the text itself gives? [DOK 4 · studentGenerated · wait 8 s · RL.9-10.2, SL.9-10.1, RL.11-12.2] Look for: A student-generated question answered from evidence.

    Answer guidance: A defensible line of argument: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Useful evidence: “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257): Her "freedom." Theme link: she is infantilized in a nursery. Credit any position that is supported by quotation and reasoning; push one-sided answers to address the strongest counterpoint.

Annotation focus

- **Point of view:** look for who is telling the story and what that narrator can and cannot know (anchor passage in the We do segment)
- Also notice **Symbolism**: objects, places or actions that stand for larger ideas
- Also notice **Imagery**: sensory details (sight, sound, cold, light) and what mood they create

Chapter quiz: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120: “There are _____ in that paper that nobody knows but me”

   Key: things

2. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In which room is the narrator kept?

   A. The library

   B. An upstairs nursery with barred windows

   C. The parlor

   D. The cellar

Key: B (An upstairs nursery with barred windows)

3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator's husband's job?

   A. Minister

   B. Physician

   C. Banker

   D. Lawyer

   Key: B (Physician)

4. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5: "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in _____"

   Key: marriage

5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: "In the daytime it is _____ and perplexing." Word bank: tiresome, provoking, splintered, congenial

   Key: tiresome

6. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern?

   A. A woman creeping and trapped

   B. A map

   C. Words

   D. A face of her mother

   Key: A (A woman creeping and trapped)

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator forbidden to do?

   A. Leave the country

   B. See her baby at all

   C. Eat meat

   D. Work and write

   Key: D (Work and write)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the story end?

   A. She escapes

   B. John faints and she creeps over him

   C. She burns the house

   D. She is cured

   Key: B (John faints and she creeps over him)

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? "There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me" (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: Obsession begins.

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of "The Yellow Wallpaper"?

    A. Confinement driving a woman into madness

    B. Guilt that the mind cannot hide

    C. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

    D. Wishes that defy fate

    Key: A (Confinement driving a woman into madness)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.
    Sample answer: Irony.

12. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.
    Sample answer: Her "freedom."

13. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120).
    Sample answer: Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Yellow Wallpaper”? The wallpaper's pattern becomes bars; the woman behind it is the narrator herself and all women confined.
    A. Symbolism
    B. Imagery
    C. Diction / vocabulary
    D. Simile

    Key: A (Symbolism)

15. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Yellow Wallpaper”? Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time.
    A. Irony
    B. Plot
    C. Point of view
    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: C (Point of view)

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.
    Sample answer: Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how oppression of women develops from an earlier story to “The Yellow Wallpaper”. Use one quotation from each.
    Sample answer: she is infantilized in a nursery.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Obsession begins.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.
    Sample answer: Irony.

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.”, what does “splintered” most nearly mean?

    A. annoying, irritating

    B. pleasant and well suited

    C. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    D. broken into sharp pieces

    Key: D (broken into sharp pieces)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “But in the places where it isn't faded, and where the sun is just so, I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure, that seems to sulk about behind that silly and conspicuous front design.”, what does “provoking” most nearly mean?

    A. annoying, irritating

    B. broken into sharp pieces

    C. pleasant and well suited

    D. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    Key: A (annoying, irritating)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Freshman	3, 1, 5, 8, 4, 7, 2, 6, 9, 10, 11, 12, 14, 15, 13, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 1
HS Sophomore	7, 2, 6, 5, 3, 1, 4, 8, 9, 11, 10, 13, 12, 14, 17, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 3, synthesis 2
HS Junior	8, 7, 5, 3, 6, 4, 2, 11, 9, 10, 12, 13, 15, 14, 19, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 2
HS Senior	4, 2, 8, 3, 5, 7, 11, 10, 9, 14, 15, 12, 13, 18, 17, 19	recall 6, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	4, 5, 7, 6, 20, 10, 9, 11, 15, 14, 13, 12, 18, 19, 17, 16	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	4, 5, 6, 8, 20, 10, 11, 9, 15, 14, 13, 12, 19, 16, 18, 17	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	5, 1, 7, 20, 8, 10, 9, 11, 14, 12, 13, 15, 17, 18, 16, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	6, 2, 4, 21, 5, 10, 9, 11, 15, 13, 12, 14, 16, 18, 17, 19	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	1, 4, 6, 5, 21, 9, 11, 10, 12, 13, 15, 14, 19, 17, 16, 18	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	5, 6, 3, 7, 1, 11, 10, 9, 13, 15, 14, 12, 17, 16, 19, 18	recall 5, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Writing prompts (eleven rigor levels)

Scaffolded support (250 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Supported track (work from the passage your teacher selects). In “The Yellow Wallpaper,” how does Gilman show confinement driving a woman into madness? Write a paragraph that states your claim, quotes two details from the passage, and explains how each detail supports your idea. Use the point of view you noticed as one piece of evidence.

HS Freshman (350 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): In The Yellow Wallpaper, how does Gilman develop the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness? State a clear claim, support it with two or three quotations, and explain how the point of view in the story helps build that idea.

HS Sophomore (450 words; Common Core: RL.9-10.1, W.9-10.1): Analyze how The Yellow Wallpaper develops the idea of confinement driving a woman into madness. Make a precise claim, support it with at least three pieces of textual evidence, and explain how the author's use of point of view and symbolism shapes that idea. Address one possible counterclaim.

HS Junior (550 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.5, RL.11-12.1, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Analyze how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (where it begins, turns and ends) and its point of view shape the reader's understanding of confinement driving a woman into madness. Identify one place where the text leaves matters uncertain and explain how that uncertainty adds to its meaning. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

HS Senior (600 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.9): Two readers disagree about what The Yellow Wallpaper suggests about confinement driving a woman into madness. Lay out two plausible interpretations, weigh the evidence for each (including the story's point of view and symbolism), and argue for the stronger one in a sustained, well-organized essay. Distinguish what is directly stated from what is really meant.

AP (650 words; Common Core: RL.11-12.6, W.11-12.1): Write a literary argument in which you analyze how Charlotte Perkins Gilman uses point of view in The Yellow Wallpaper to complicate the reader's understanding of confinement driving a woman into madness. Develop a defensible thesis, select evidence purposefully, and explain how specific choices of diction and syntax create meaning.

College Freshman (1000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Situate The Yellow Wallpaper within its historical and literary context and argue how the story's treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness responds to that context. Engage with at least one secondary perspective (a critic, historian or the author's own statements), integrate quotations smoothly, and cite in MLA style.

College Sophomore (1250 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Read The Yellow Wallpaper alongside the conventions of its genre and period. Argue how the story's handling of confinement driving a woman into madness follows or bends those conventions, using the point of view as evidence, and test your reading against one published critic. Document two secondary sources in MLA.

College Junior (1500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Apply a named critical approach (for example formalist, historicist, feminist, psychoanalytic or ecocritical) to The Yellow Wallpaper and its treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness. State your method, show what it reveals in the story's point of view and symbolism, and identify where the text resists it.

College Senior (2000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop a research argument that reads The Yellow Wallpaper as evidence for a larger claim about confinement driving a woman into madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Connect close reading of the story to the whole story, engage at least four scholarly sources, and state precisely where your reading departs from theirs (Chicago style).

Graduate / PhD (2500 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Develop an original argument that reads The Yellow Wallpaper as a hinge in the story's larger treatment of confinement driving a woman into madness. Position your reading within a named critical conversation (for example formalist, historicist, psychoanalytic, feminist or postcolonial approaches), account for the textual history where relevant, and articulate the stakes of your intervention for scholarship on The Yellow Wallpaper.

SAT-style questions

1. *Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.*

   As used in the text, what does the word “splintered” most nearly mean?

   A. so lacking in interest as to cause mental weariness

   B. making one feel ashamed and foolish

   C. annoying, irritating

   D. broken into sharp pieces

2. *Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.*

   Which choice best states a central concern of “The Yellow Wallpaper”?

   A. Love and rivalry destroyed by racial violence

   B. Harlem as promised refuge and trap

   C. Confinement driving a woman into madness

   D. The cost of wanting to seem richer than you are

SAT key: 1. D (broken into sharp pieces); 2. C (Confinement driving a woman into madness)

Unit test

The Yellow Wallpaper: end test · 90 minutes · 18 questions per rigor version (multiple choice, fill in the blank, short answer). The class rigor level picks the version; student auto-adjust applies.

Short-answer scoring guides

Scaffolded support and HS Freshman (2 points): correct answer in a complete sentence with a detail from the text. HS Sophomore to HS Senior (3 points): claim, one accurate quotation, one sentence of explanation. AP to College Sophomore (4 points): precise claim, two embedded quotations, commentary on word choice or structure, link to theme. College Junior to Graduate (5 points): nuanced thesis, close reading of two passages, synthesis across sections, a competing reading answered. Each item lists a sample answer; partial credit is described in the app.

Unit test: item bank (all eleven rigor versions)

1. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What does she see behind the wallpaper's pattern?
   A. A woman creeping and trapped
   B. A map
   C. Words
   D. A face of her mother

   Key: A (A woman creeping and trapped)
2. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120: “There are _____ in that paper that nobody knows but me”

   Key: things
3. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In which room is the narrator kept?
   A. The library
   B. An upstairs nursery with barred windows
   C. The parlor
   D. The cellar

   Key: B (An upstairs nursery with barred windows)
4. [mc · recall · DOK 1] How does the story end?
   A. She escapes
   B. John faints and she creeps over him
   C. She burns the house
   D. She is cured

   Key: B (John faints and she creeps over him)
5. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Complete the quotation from The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5: “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in _____”

   Key: marriage

6. [fill · recall · DOK 1] Fill in the blank with the vocabulary word that fits: “In the daytime it is _____ and perplexing.” Word bank: tiresome, provoking, splintered, congenial

   Key: tiresome

7. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator forbidden to do?

   A. Leave the country

   B. See her baby at all

   C. Eat meat

   D. Work and write

   Key: D (Work and write)

8. [mc · recall · DOK 1] What is the narrator's husband's job?

   A. Minister

   B. Physician

   C. Banker

   D. Lawyer

   Key: B (Physician)

9. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

   Sample answer: Irony.

10. [mc · inference · DOK 2] Which choice best states a central concern of “The Yellow Wallpaper”?

    A. Confinement driving a woman into madness

    B. Guilt that the mind cannot hide

    C. Accepting one's place in nature's cycle

    D. Wishes that defy fate

    Key: A (Confinement driving a woman into madness)

11. [short · inference · DOK 2] What can you infer from this line? “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120) Answer in two or three sentences with one detail.

    Sample answer: Obsession begins.

12. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Yellow Wallpaper”? Secret journal entries: the reader sees the narrator's mind deteriorate in real time.

    A. Irony

    B. Plot

    C. Point of view

    D. Diction / vocabulary

    Key: C (Point of view)

13. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Analyze the word choice in “I've got out at last” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 257). Pick two words and explain what they suggest.

    Sample answer: Her "freedom."

14. [mc · analysis · DOK 3] Which literary element does this describe in “The Yellow Wallpaper”? The wallpaper's pattern becomes bars; the woman behind it is the narrator herself and all women confined.

    A. Symbolism

B. Imagery

C. Diction / vocabulary

D. Simile

Key: A (Symbolism)

15. [short · analysis · DOK 3] Claim: The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement. Explain how this evidence supports the claim: “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120).

    Sample answer: Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

16. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 5) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Irony.

17. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Evaluate this claim about the story: “The narrator's madness is a response to her confinement.” Is it fully persuasive? Argue with evidence, including a passage that complicates it.

    Sample answer: Early, she remarks that "John laughs at me, of course, but one expects that in marriage"; forbidden to work, she fixes on the paper ("There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me") and finally claims "I've got out at last," freedom found only in madness.

18. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Synthesis: trace how oppression of women develops from an earlier story to “The Yellow Wallpaper”. Use one quotation from each.

    Sample answer: she is infantilized in a nursery.

19. [short · synthesis · DOK 4] Close reading: how do the diction and syntax of “There are things in that paper that nobody knows but me” (The Yellow Wallpaper, paragraph 120) shape its meaning? Consider a second, competing reading.

    Sample answer: Obsession begins.

20. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Personally I believe that congenial work, with excitement and change, would do me good.”, what does “congenial” most nearly mean?

    A. pleasant and well suited

    B. annoying, irritating

    C. broken into sharp pieces

    D. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    Key: A (pleasant and well suited)

21. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “It must be very humiliating to be caught creeping by daylight!”, what does “humiliating” most nearly mean?

    A. broken into sharp pieces

    B. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    C. pleasant and well suited

    D. annoying, irritating

    Key: B (making one feel ashamed and foolish)

22. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “But in the places where it isn't faded, and where the sun is just so, I can see a strange, provoking, formless sort of figure, that seems to sulk about behind that silly and conspicuous front design.”, what does “provoking” most nearly mean?

    A. annoying, irritating

    B. broken into sharp pieces

    C. pleasant and well suited

    D. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    Key: A (annoying, irritating)

23. [mc · recall · DOK 1] In the line “Then the floor is scratched and gouged and splintered, the plaster itself is dug out here and there, and this great heavy bed, which is all we found in the room, looks as if it had been through the wars.”, what does “splintered” most nearly mean?

    A. annoying, irritating

    B. pleasant and well suited

    C. making one feel ashamed and foolish

    D. broken into sharp pieces

    Key: D (broken into sharp pieces)

Rigor version	Items (in order)	Mix
Scaffolded support	1, 2, 3, 4, 5, 6, 7, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 13, 14, 15, 16, 17, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Freshman	8, 7, 5, 1, 4, 3, 6, 2, 11, 9, 10, 14, 15, 12, 13, 18, 16, 17	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Sophomore	6, 1, 2, 5, 4, 8, 3, 7, 10, 11, 9, 14, 12, 13, 15, 17, 16, 18	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Junior	5, 3, 4, 6, 7, 8, 1, 2, 11, 10, 9, 12, 15, 13, 14, 18, 16, 19	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
HS Senior	8, 6, 4, 2, 7, 1, 5, 3, 10, 11, 9, 13, 14, 15, 12, 17, 18, 16	recall 8, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 3
AP	5, 7, 3, 20, 2, 8, 21, 10, 11, 9, 15, 12, 14, 13, 16, 18, 17, 19	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Freshman	21, 8, 6, 1, 4, 22, 5, 11, 10, 9, 14, 13, 15, 12, 19, 18, 17, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Sophomore	6, 20, 5, 1, 8, 22, 7, 9, 10, 11, 13, 14, 15, 12, 18, 19, 17, 16	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Junior	2, 7, 3, 22, 6, 20, 8, 9, 10, 11, 12, 15, 13, 14, 16, 19, 18, 17	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
College Senior	6, 3, 1, 22, 21, 2, 23, 10, 11, 9, 13, 12, 15, 14, 19, 16, 17, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4
Graduate / PhD	5, 6, 4, 22, 21, 3, 8, 11, 10, 9, 14, 15, 13, 12, 17, 16, 19, 18	recall 7, inference 3, analysis 4, synthesis 4

Final paper

The Yellow Wallpaper: final paper (formal literary analysis). Choose one prompt.

1. Analyze how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops women and medical authority across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three moments (beginning, middle and end) and argue what the ending finally suggests.
2. Choose one recurring symbol, image or motif in The Yellow Wallpaper and argue how its meaning changes over the story and why that change matters to confinement and madness.
3. Analyze a central character's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper. Argue whether the story judges that character, and how its structure or point of view shapes your answer.
4. Two readers disagree about whether The Yellow Wallpaper finally endorses or criticizes its society's view of voice and silence. Weigh both readings and argue for one, answering the strongest objection.

Length: Scaffolded support 500-700 words; HS Freshman 700-900 words; HS Sophomore 900-1,100 words; HS Junior 1,000-1,300 words; HS Senior 1,200-1,500 words; AP 1,300-1,600 words; College Freshman 1,500-2,000 words; College Sophomore 2,000-2,500 words; College Junior 2,500-3,000 words; College Senior 3,000-4,000 words; Graduate / PhD 4,000-6,000 words

Evidence requirement: at least 4 quotations from at least two parts of the story. Quote the reading text exactly and cite the paragraph (MLA style). HS Senior and above: one scholarly or historical source; College Sophomore and above: two, cited in MLA.

Criterion	Points	Descriptor
Thesis	20	A specific, arguable claim that answers the prompt and organizes the paper.
Evidence	25	Well-chosen, accurately quoted and cited passages from across the work, meeting the evidence requirement.
Analysis	30	Explains how language, structure and literary elements create meaning; goes beyond summary.
Organization	15	Logical progression, clear topic sentences and transitions; introduction and conclusion frame the argument.
Style and conventions	10	Formal academic voice, present tense for literature, correct grammar and MLA format.

Essay assignments

Essay: Women and medical authority

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about women and medical authority. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops women and medical authority across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of women and medical authority. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of women and medical authority, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of women and medical authority in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Senior (4000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a research paper (12–15 pages) with an original argument about women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging at least four

scholarly sources in Chicago style. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on women and medical authority in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Confinement and madness

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about confinement and madness. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops confinement and madness across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of confinement and madness. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of confinement and madness, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of confinement and madness in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

College Junior (2800 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a theoretically informed essay (8–10 pages) on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper. Name your critical method, apply it closely, and acknowledge its limits. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Graduate / PhD (6000 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a seminar paper (15–20 pages) that intervenes in the critical conversation on confinement and madness in The Yellow Wallpaper, engaging the relevant scholarship and textual history. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

Essay: Voice and silence

Scaffolded support (600 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Supported track: write a five-paragraph essay explaining what The Yellow Wallpaper teaches about voice and silence. Use at least three quotations from passages your teacher selects from different parts of the book.

HS Freshman (800 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write a multi-paragraph essay explaining how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper. Use evidence from the beginning, middle and end of the book.

HS Sophomore (1000 words; Common Core: W.9-10.1, RL.9-10.2): Write an argumentative essay analyzing how Charlotte Perkins Gilman develops voice and silence across The Yellow Wallpaper. Trace the idea through at least three parts of the story and address a counterclaim.

HS Junior (1100 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.5): Write an analytical essay on how the structure of The Yellow Wallpaper (its order, turns and ending) shapes the meaning of voice and silence. Discuss at least one place where the book leaves the question open.

HS Senior (1200 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a sustained argument comparing two interpretations of voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper. Weigh the evidence for each and defend the stronger reading in a mature, well-organized essay.

AP (1300 words; Common Core: W.11-12.1, RL.11-12.2): Write a literary argument: develop a defensible thesis about how Charlotte Perkins Gilman's choices in The Yellow Wallpaper (a recurring element, structure and narration) shape a complex understanding of voice and silence, weigh at least one competing reading, and sustain commentary on well-chosen evidence. Do not merely summarize.

College Freshman (1600 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a researched essay (4–6 pages) that places The Yellow Wallpaper's treatment of voice and silence in its historical context, using at least two scholarly sources.

College Sophomore (2200 words; Common Core: see unit standards): Write a contextual essay (6–8 pages) on voice and silence in The Yellow Wallpaper that reads the story against its genre and period and engages two published critics. At this level students write ONE of the unit's essays (choose one theme), not all five.

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Rubric: Claim · Evidence · Analysis · Organization · Conventions

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